

Demos of tables with `kable()` in knitr

Yihui Xie

September 22, 2026

The function `kable()` is a simple table generator. Unlike sophisticated packages (e.g. `xtable`, which has more than 30 arguments), this function only has a minimal number of arguments to generate simple tables.

```
library(knitr)
kable(head(iris))
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
5.1	3.5	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.9	3.0	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.7	3.2	1.3	0.2	setosa
4.6	3.1	1.5	0.2	setosa
5.0	3.6	1.4	0.2	setosa
5.4	3.9	1.7	0.4	setosa

```
kable(head(iris, 0))
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
--------------	-------------	--------------	-------------	---------

```
kable(head(iris, 1))
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
5.1	3.5	1.4	0.2	setosa

1 No row names

```
kable(head(iris), row.names = FALSE)
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
5.1	3.5	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.9	3.0	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.7	3.2	1.3	0.2	setosa
4.6	3.1	1.5	0.2	setosa
5.0	3.6	1.4	0.2	setosa
5.4	3.9	1.7	0.4	setosa

2 At most 3 digits

```
kable(matrix(rnorm(20), 4), digits = 3)
```

-0.560	0.129	-0.687	0.401	0.498
-0.230	1.715	-0.446	0.111	-1.967
1.559	0.461	1.224	-0.556	0.701
0.071	-1.265	0.360	1.787	-0.473

3 Alignment

By default, numeric columns are right-aligned, and other columns are left-aligned.

```
kable(head(iris), align = c("l", "c", "r", "l", "r"))
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
5.1	3.5	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.9	3.0	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.7	3.2	1.3	0.2	setosa
4.6	3.1	1.5	0.2	setosa
5.0	3.6	1.4	0.2	setosa
5.4	3.9	1.7	0.4	setosa

4 Default tables are ugly

Let's use the **booktabs** package. The air is suddenly fresh!

```
kable(head(iris), row.names = FALSE, booktabs = TRUE)
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
5.1	3.5	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.9	3.0	1.4	0.2	setosa
4.7	3.2	1.3	0.2	setosa
4.6	3.1	1.5	0.2	setosa
5.0	3.6	1.4	0.2	setosa
5.4	3.9	1.7	0.4	setosa

```
kable(head(iris, 0), row.names = FALSE, booktabs = TRUE)
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
--------------	-------------	--------------	-------------	---------

```
kable(head(iris, 1), row.names = FALSE, booktabs = TRUE)
```

Sepal.Length	Sepal.Width	Petal.Length	Petal.Width	Species
5.1	3.5	1.4	0.2	setosa

```
kable(head(mtcars[, 1:7]), booktabs = TRUE)
```

	mpg	cyl	disp	hp	drat	wt	qsec
Mazda RX4	21.0	6	160	110	3.90	2.620	16.46
Mazda RX4 Wag	21.0	6	160	110	3.90	2.875	17.02
Datsun 710	22.8	4	108	93	3.85	2.320	18.61
Hornet 4 Drive	21.4	6	258	110	3.08	3.215	19.44
Hornet Sportabout	18.7	8	360	175	3.15	3.440	17.02
Valiant	18.1	6	225	105	2.76	3.460	20.22

5 Long tables

```
kable(mtcars[, 1:7], longtable = TRUE, booktabs = TRUE)
```

	mpg	cyl	disp	hp	drat	wt	qsec
Mazda RX4	21.0	6	160.0	110	3.90	2.620	16.46
Mazda RX4 Wag	21.0	6	160.0	110	3.90	2.875	17.02
Datsun 710	22.8	4	108.0	93	3.85	2.320	18.61
Hornet 4 Drive	21.4	6	258.0	110	3.08	3.215	19.44
Hornet Sportabout	18.7	8	360.0	175	3.15	3.440	17.02
Valiant	18.1	6	225.0	105	2.76	3.460	20.22
Duster 360	14.3	8	360.0	245	3.21	3.570	15.84
Merc 240D	24.4	4	146.7	62	3.69	3.190	20.00
Merc 230	22.8	4	140.8	95	3.92	3.150	22.90
Merc 280	19.2	6	167.6	123	3.92	3.440	18.30
Merc 280C	17.8	6	167.6	123	3.92	3.440	18.90
Merc 450SE	16.4	8	275.8	180	3.07	4.070	17.40
Merc 450SL	17.3	8	275.8	180	3.07	3.730	17.60
Merc 450SLC	15.2	8	275.8	180	3.07	3.780	18.00
Cadillac Fleetwood	10.4	8	472.0	205	2.93	5.250	17.98
Lincoln Continental	10.4	8	460.0	215	3.00	5.424	17.82
Chrysler Imperial	14.7	8	440.0	230	3.23	5.345	17.42
Fiat 128	32.4	4	78.7	66	4.08	2.200	19.47
Honda Civic	30.4	4	75.7	52	4.93	1.615	18.52
Toyota Corolla	33.9	4	71.1	65	4.22	1.835	19.90

Toyota Corona	21.5	4	120.1	97	3.70	2.465	20.01
Dodge Challenger	15.5	8	318.0	150	2.76	3.520	16.87
AMC Javelin	15.2	8	304.0	150	3.15	3.435	17.30
Camaro Z28	13.3	8	350.0	245	3.73	3.840	15.41
Pontiac Firebird	19.2	8	400.0	175	3.08	3.845	17.05
Fiat X1-9	27.3	4	79.0	66	4.08	1.935	18.90
Porsche 914-2	26.0	4	120.3	91	4.43	2.140	16.70
Lotus Europa	30.4	4	95.1	113	3.77	1.513	16.90
Ford Pantera L	15.8	8	351.0	264	4.22	3.170	14.50
Ferrari Dino	19.7	6	145.0	175	3.62	2.770	15.50
Maserati Bora	15.0	8	301.0	335	3.54	3.570	14.60
Volvo 142E	21.4	4	121.0	109	4.11	2.780	18.60

6 Want more features?

No, that is all I have. You should turn to other packages for help. I'm not going to reinvent their wheels.